

UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

THURSDAY, 24 SEPTEMBER 2026

11 must-know stories, 9 Prelims facts, 15 editorials and 8 explainers, picked from 160 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Karnataka Shops & Commercial Establishments (Amendment) Act 2026: Key Details

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Where: Karnataka

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

[India Briefing: read the source](#)

Governance & Policy

GS2

MAKE NOTES

NITI Aayog launches Investment Friendliness Index to benchmark states on investment ecosystem

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Who: NITI Aayog

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Report/Index

[DD News: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Census-2027 Phase | Akashvani News

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Report/Index

[News On AIR: read the source](#)

International Relations

GS2

MAKE NOTES

UPSC Issue at a Glance | BRICS Summit 2026: From its expansion and challenges to what India's presidency achieved

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Who: BRICS

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations

[Indian Express: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

India-US trade deal 'done and dusted', execution awaits competitive advantage: Goyal

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal announced that the US-India bilateral trade agreement is on the verge of completion, showcasing significant progress. He also emphasized positive developments in the India-EU trade negotiations, particularly regarding climate regulations, and mentioned advancements in talks with Canada, Mexico, and the Gulf Cooperation Council. Goyal also outlined progress with the European Union, Canada, Mexico, the Gulf Cooperation Council, Chile and Peru on trade agreements

Where: US, Canada, Mexico, European Union · Who: Piyush Goyal (Minister)

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[Economic Times: read the source](#)

Health

GS2

MAKE NOTES

FSSAI proposes draft amendment to ensure only milk-derived products are represented as ‘Paneer’

The proposed Food Safety and Standards (Prohibition and Restrictions on Sales) Amendment Regulations, 2026 seek to insert a new clause under Regulation 2.1.1 of the existing regulations, specifically covering “paneer made of constituents not derived from milk”

Who: FSSAI

Syllabus: GS2: Health, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

[The Hindu: read the source](#)

Infrastructure & Energy

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

NHAI Releases New Guidelines for High-Speed Access-Controlled National Highways

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Infrastructure & Energy, Governance & Policy

[News On AIR: read the source](#)

Environment & Ecology

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

Refinery sector must balance energy security with net-zero push: industry experts at The Hindu Sustainability Summit

At a discussion about ‘Fossils to Net Zero: Transforming India’s Refinery and Energy Landscape’, the panel touched on renewable energy, geopolitical disruptions on crude supplies, and the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme...

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Environment & Ecology, Infrastructure & Energy, International Relations · Prelims angle: Scheme

[The Hindu: read the source](#)

Science & Technology

GS3

MAKE NOTES

DRDO Signs First High-Value Deep-Tech Project Agreement

Only the headline was reported; open the source for the details.

Who: DRDO

Syllabus: GS3: Science & Technology, Defence · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[defencewatch.in: read the source](#)

Internal Security

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

Designation of terrorist organisation under clause (a) of sub-section (1) of section 35 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967 and listed in the First Schedule of the Act

RBI/2026-2027/270 DOR.AML.REC.233/14.06.001/2026-27 September 24, 2026 The Chairpersons/ CEOs of the Commercial Banks, Small Finance Banks, Payment Banks, Urban Co-operative Banks, Rural Co-operative Banks, Regional Rural Banks, Local Area Banks, Non-Banking Financial Companies, Asset Reconstruction Companies, All India Financial Institutions Madam/Dear Sir, Designation of terrorist organisation under clause (a) of sub-section (1) of section 35 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967 and listed in the First Schedule of the Act In terms of Chapter IX on “Requirements/obligations under International Agreements - Communications from International Agencies” of the Reserve Bank of...

Who: RBI

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Internal Security, Polity & Constitution, Economy · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

[RBI: read the source](#)

Defence

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

India-Mongolia joint military exercise 'Nomadic Elephant 2026' underway in Uttarakhand

The 18th edition of the India-Mongolia Joint Military Exercise 'Nomadic Elephant 2026' is being held from September 21 to October 3, 2026, at the Foreign Training Node in Pithoragarh, with troops of the Indian Army and Mongolian Armed Forces undertaking intensive training focused on improving interoperability, tactical proficiency and mutual understanding.

Where: Uttarakhand

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Defence, Environment & Ecology, International Relations · Prelims angle: Species, Exercise

[Economic Times: read the source](#)

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

SOCIAL JUSTICE & WELFARE

ACT/BILL/RULES

QUICK READ

Expects states, UTs to notify labour Code rules by October 31: Centre

Ten states have already published their rules, while the remaining states and Union Territories have issued drafts for consultation, Labour Secretary Chandra Bhushan Kumar said...

[Business Standard: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

EAM's Opening Statement during the Forum for India-Pacific Islands Cooperation (FIPIC) Foreign Ministers' Meeting

[Ministry of External Affairs: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

SPECIES

QUICK READ

New Begonia species described from Arunachal Pradesh

Begonia neelamorum, found in Keyi Panyor district and named after the Neelam clan of the Nyishi community, is the 54th Begonia species recorded from India's northeastern region...

[The Hindu: source](#)

GOVERNANCE & POLICY

QUICK READ

India-ROK Comprehensive Framework for Partnership in Shipbuilding, Shipping and Maritime Logistics

[Ministry of External Affairs: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

AGREEMENT/MOU

QUICK READ

India-EU FTA to be signed on December 16

The signing will be part of Prime Minister Modi's upcoming trips in December to Canada, the U.S., and Belgium, where three separate FTAs are currently either being negotiated or in the process of approval...

[The Hindu: source](#)

POLITY & CONSTITUTION

ACT/BILL/RULES

QUICK READ

Europe's proposed KIDS Act and what India can learn

The European Commission proposes a minimum age of 15 for autonomous social media accounts and wants platforms to redesign features that encourage compulsive use.

[Frontline: source](#)

DEFENCE

QUICK READ

US envoy Sergio Gor, Lt Gen Deshpande witness joint firing at Yudh Abhyas 2026

[defencewatch.in: source](#)

AGRICULTURE & ALLIED

SPECIES

QUICK READ

ICAR-CMFRI, Kochi describes new eel species from Arabian Sea

[Indian Council Of Agricultural Research: source](#)

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

SPECIES

QUICK READ

New Frog species discovered in Amazon's flooded forests, revealing hidden biodiversity

[Moneycontrol.com: source](#)

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS2 GS3 Beyond numbers: Why India's electoral rolls, census and GDP need public trust

Recent activities related to GDP, census, and electoral rolls reflect deep concerns regarding transparency and trust. Ongoing processes aim to ensure effective governance and participation in democracy. Analysts highlight that discrepancies and disputes must be addressed to maintain public confidence. Furthermore, addressing citizens' rights and needs is vital for social justice and economic development. Ultimately, these efforts require sincere intentions from all stakeholders involved to foster trust in democratic processes.

[Economic Times](#)

GS2 India's election umpire must play by its own rulebook

Recent allegations against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar suggest unilateral actions disregarding his colleagues' views. The amendments to Form 6 may not have followed proper legal procedures, raising significant concerns. Section 13B and 13CC of the Representation of the People Act 1950 define the roles of electoral registration officers. Allegations about software curbing the authority of these officers contribute to the controversy.

[Economic Times](#)

GS3 Mint Quick Edit | India's economy has held up against global headwinds quite impressively

The country's growth outlook has brightened, as noted by credit rating agencies like Fitch, S&P and Moody's. If India lives up to their raised GDP projections, it will testify to the tenacity of its economy.

[Mint](#)

GS2 Deep rot: On the Election Commission of India's functioning during its SIR

With the SIR thoroughly vitiated, CEC Gyanesh Kumar must resign

[The Hindu](#)

GS3 How RBI's rules for gadget loan recovery can make a positive difference for India on many counts

The Reserve Bank of India's new rules that enable the use of technology tools to ensure loans for smartphones and other devices are duly repaid could drive up demand for these items. The idea can boost economic inclusion by taking gadget credit far and wide.

[Mint](#)

GS2 Best of BS Opinion: Brics' New Delhi Declaration needs follow-up from India

From the bank strike and prohibition debate to WTO reform, infrastructure risk-sharing and the history of data, today's opinions examine policy choices, institutional design and their consequences...

[Business Standard](#)

GS2 What Delhi PG Safety Bill must have is teeth, not symbolism

The discussion around Delhi's proposed PG Safety Bill appears reactive, framed around the Satya Niketan tragedy. That is worrisome when the matter is one of rights rather than optics.

[ThePrint](#)

GS2 Presumed ineligible: On the Election Commission of India's SIR process

The Election Commission of India must end its method of deleting first and verifying later

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 Trading smart: On the India-New Zealand FTA

The India-NZ FTA shows how smaller deals can complement big-bang trade pacts

[The Hindu](#)

GS3 Help India's informal sector thrive: it supports mass livelihoods and has its own institutions of trust

The informal sector's interests matter. It accounts for nearly 90% of India's workforce but functions on trust, reputation and relationships—its very own institutions. Indian policy, bent on formalization, must aim to strengthen and not replace this sector.

[Mint](#)

GS2 GS3 Would AI run India's elections better?

With the country's election machinery already raising questions about human judgment, perhaps we should see what happens when we hand the job to a machine.

[Frontline](#)

GS2 GS4 Need to repair the Nirvachan Vachan

Recent investigations have unveiled deep divisions within the Election Commission concerning critical decision-making frameworks. Under chief commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi have expressed substantial concerns. The ongoing debate about the integrity of electoral rolls and voter eligibility highlights the urgent need for the Commission to clarify its processes. Restoring public confidence hinges on addressing these procedural lapses transparently.

[Economic Times](#)

GS2 India and the plausible multilateralism of BRICS

The very structure of BRICS offers India space to pursue strategic autonomy amid intensifying great-power rivalries

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 Editorial. Why Chinese President Xi Jinping's visit to India has drawn considerable attention

China-India ties in renewed state of flux

[BusinessLine](#)

GS2 SIR and electoral rights: The unequal burden of proving you belong on the voter roll

Open the piece for its argument.

[Deccan Herald](#)

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

How will new NCAHP regulations impact allied and healthcare professionals? The regulations will facilitate the identification and verification of registered professionals and support greater transparency in the delivery of allied and healthcare services.

[The Hindu](#)

Knowledge Nugget | Hurricane Polo: What it tells us about tropical cyclones

[Indian Express](#)

Why has Andhra Pradesh raised the age limit for govt. jobs, and who is still left out? Age relief rekindles hopes of job aspirants a year before the relaxation lapses; uniform-service candidates seek a wider window

[The Hindu](#)

Can India Turn the CBAM Challenge into an Opportunity?

[orfonline.org](#)

Mint Explainer | Why NHRC wants India's drugs regulator to build a national digital registry

[Mint](#)

Explainer: The worrying trend of youth chasing neither jobs nor skills

[financialexpress.com](#)

Mint Explainer | Are AI companies reshaping India's ad market?

[Mint](#)

How Japan's Shinkansen technology will help India's bullet train switch tracks at 320 kmph

[ThePrint](#)

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- India-Mexico may sign trade pact, report reveals: Autos, pharma, engineering—who stands to gain? (International Relations) [Mint](#)
- Rajasthan's Painted Haveli Towns deserve World Heritage status, says UNESCO regional head (History, Art & Culture) [ThePrint](#)
- Germany has finalised an \$8 billion deal with India for next-generation submarines: Jasper Weick (Defence) [Economic Times](#)
- Safety most important in managing forex reserves says RBI Deputy Governor Rohit Jain (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- Why India's Election Commission is in the eye of a storm (Polity & Constitution) [BBC News](#)
- India-EU FTA to boost Indian exports, spur Danish investment in India: Denmark envoy Kristensen (International Relations) [Economic Times](#)
- India's new FTAs offer investors tariff predictability: Commerce Secretary (International Relations) [Business Standard](#)
- Three-language policy case: Centre given more time to mull SC proposal to exempt current Class 6 (Education) [The Hindu](#)
- BRICS tax model needs to reflect reality: FM Nirmala Sitharaman (International Relations) [Economic Times](#)
- 'Super El Niño' projected to cause 15,800 additional heat deaths in India, says report (Environment & Ecology) [The Hindu](#)
- India postpones Cambodia tiger reintroduction (Environment & Ecology) [Mongabay India](#)
- Irdai commission caps may weigh on insurance fee income of banks, NBFCs (Economy) [Business Standard](#)
- Blind snake that looks like a massive earthworm discovered on roadside in China (International Relations) [discoverwildlife.com](#)
- India's UPI Sets Global Benchmark Supporting 20 Billion Transactions Monthly: Report (Economy) [Ommcom News](#)
- Key decisions taken in the SEBI Board Meeting dated 24th September, 2026 (Economy) [SEBI](#)
- CAG Report State Wise Salary Pension Percentage Telugu (Polity & Constitution) [Zee News](#)
- India's Emerging Drought Stress: Monsoon Variability and Agricultural Risks (Agriculture & Allied) [NEXT IAS](#)
- Tripura Lost 4,000 Crore Annual GAP Fund After 15th Finance Commission: Minister Pranajit Singha Roy (Governance & Policy) [northeasttoday.in](#)

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 11 must-know, 9 Prelims facts, 18 in the news, 15 editorials, 8 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — International Relations (4), Governance & Policy (3), Environment & Ecology (3), Defence (2), Polity & Constitution (2), Internal Security (1), Health (1), Infrastructure & Energy (1), Science & Technology (1), Social Justice & Welfare (1), Agriculture & Allied (1). **Nothing today in** — Education, Economy, Disaster Management, History, Art & Culture, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 1 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 1 · Political change in the neighbourhood: nothing today · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: nothing today · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 2

Full text — 0 of 43 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 10, Economic Times 5, Mint 5, Indian Express 2, News On AIR 2, defencewatch.in 2, Business Standard 2, Ministry of External Affairs 2, Frontline 2, ThePrint 2, RBI 1, DD News 1, India Briefing 1, Indian Council Of Agricultural Research 1

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